Homework 1 (CS59300 ASE)

Reflection on Building Papertrail with Codex

vichytong October 9, 2026

I used Codex to build Papertrail, an AI research assistant for finding papers, keeping a local library, uploading PDFs, and using an LLM to summarize and question their contents. This report was prepared with Codex assistance using my personal reflection supplied on October 9 and the recorded development work. The personal experience and the agent's technical checks are identified separately below.

1. Choosing and using Codex

I chose Codex because I liked its user interface and found the newer models useful. My initial request was short: read the assignment, help complete its requirements, and give the frontend clean colors and a concise style. I provided the assignment rather than a detailed implementation plan. Codex then worked through the frontend, backend, external services, persistence, PDF processing, verification, and documentation.

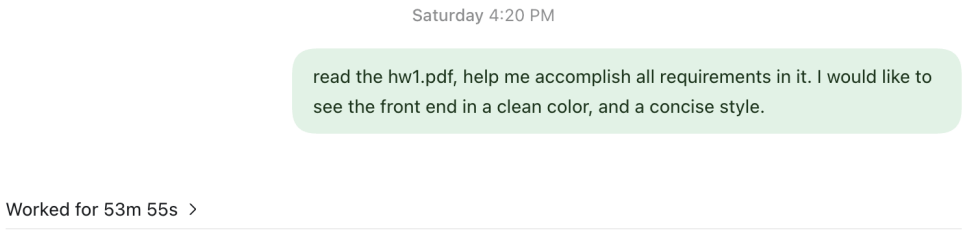


Figure 1. My initial instruction supplied the assignment and the preference for clean colors and a concise interface. The original screenshot also records a first work period of 53 minutes and 55 seconds.

The resulting application uses Flask, SQLite, pypdf, the arXiv API, and an OpenAI-compatible LLM API, with HTML, CSS, and JavaScript for the frontend. Papertrail has a light sage-and-white interface with discovery, library, and reading views. The agent selected and connected these components; my instructions supplied the task, visual direction, and later model choice.

What surprised me most was its ability to keep working on a long task. Beyond the assignment itself, I had given only a brief description of my preferences, yet the first run continued for almost an hour. Seeing a short request lead to sustained implementation and checking was more striking to me than any individual generated function. That duration does not establish correctness by itself, but it changed my impression of how much work an agent can carry through from one instruction.

2. Where the agent was useful

The clearest contribution was connecting the required features into one usable workflow. A search result needs metadata and a durable library record. A saved or uploaded paper needs extracted text before the model can analyze it. The interface also needs to show progress, errors, saved answers, and a path back to the source. Codex handled those connections across multiple files rather than leaving me with separate feature demonstrations.

The content-grounding requirement was especially important. The application sends extracted PDF text to the model, keeps physical PDF page numbers, and saves answers with source excerpts. It uses the full text when it fits the context

budget and labels the use of excerpts for longer papers. These choices make an answer easier to inspect, although page references do not guarantee a correct interpretation.

Persistence was another useful part of the implementation. SQLite stores papers and analysis history, file hashes detect duplicate uploads, and repeated identical successful analysis requests reuse saved responses. The agent also checked a less visible case: deleting one record should preserve PDF bytes that another record still uses. This illustrates the integration work behind a simple-looking interface.

3. Failures, incomplete results, and corrections

A. Search and PDF metadata needed real examples

The initial search required every word in a query. The natural title `attention is all you need` returned no results during verification, while the arXiv ID `1706.03762` found the paper. Codex changed the query construction to omit common English stop words and added a regression check. The resulting keyword search is broader than an exact-title lookup, so the ID remains useful for retrieving a known paper.

Uploading the real PDF exposed a second problem. The parser chose a reproduction notice as the title, left the authors empty, and selected 2014 from a dataset reference as the publication year. Earlier checks with a simple synthetic PDF had not exposed this. Codex added identifier-based arXiv metadata enrichment, improved title and publication-year heuristics, and retained an editable review form. The corrected example shows the proper title, eight authors, 2017, and abstract in Evidence B.

These repairs were found and carried out by the agent during its checks. I do not attribute those individual diagnoses to myself. Evidence A preserves the visible failed metadata as a labeled transcription, and the original before/after captures are retained in the evidence folder. The three conversation screenshots document the initial request and the AI setup/model follow-up; they do not show the internal search or metadata debugging exchanges.

The important limitation is that a clean test fixture did not represent the structure of an actual research paper. Notices, footnotes, columns, and dataset years all complicated extraction. Testing a representative document revealed problems that a successful basic upload test could not rule out.

B. The first delivery still needed a working AI connection

The initial delivery reported that the five features had been implemented, but live summaries and Q&A still depended on my API configuration. Figure 2 shows this unfinished step and my response that I would configure the local `.env` file. I then supplied the key locally and explicitly asked for `gpt-6-luna` because it was cheaper. Figure 3 shows that instruction and the agent's subsequent report of successful real summaries, Q&A, saved-result reuse, and 14 passing tests.

This was a concrete case where a delivered implementation still needed my input before the complete workflow could be verified. The follow-up changed both the model configuration and what could be tested. It also showed that credentials and model choice are requirements to settle early, rather than details to discover at the end. The API key stayed in an ignored local file.

C. I redirected the report-rendering approach

Some of my later corrections concerned the presentation of the results. The PNG application figures were not clear enough, so I asked for PDF or SVG. When saving the PDF through computer use kept failing, I specifically asked the agent to stop using computer use and render from HTML. It produced a vector PDF from the application's HTML/CSS and saved paper data. I then requested black report text.

These instructions named an observable problem, a desired output, and a constraint on the method. The application figures now retain selectable text when enlarged. The historical failure page is explicitly a transcription, while the corrected metadata page is a direct HTML/CSS rendering with a print layout that exposes all authors and the abstract. The original conversation screenshots remain unchanged. These later corrections are part of the conversation record, but are not shown in the three supplied screenshots.

4. My review and the agent's verification

I personally tried all five required functions: searching for papers, saving them to the library, uploading a PDF, generating a summary, and asking questions. This is the review I can report directly from my own experience. The detailed code repairs, automated checks, and process-level persistence checks described here were performed by Codex. I separate my functional review from those checks rather than presenting the agent's work as my own manual debugging.

Fourteen automated tests passed after the corrections. They use temporary databases and mocked external responses. Separate live checks on October 4 established that `gpt-6-luna` could produce a real summary and answer from the paper content, and that repeated requests reused saved results. A grouped-page-reference format in the answer also exposed a frontend linking gap that Codex repaired.

On October 9, Codex repeated the README setup in a fresh Python environment with the example configuration and a new database. Dependency checks and all 14 tests passed. Actual HTTP checks confirmed startup, upload, the missing-key message, and data persistence after a process restart.

The remaining limitations are practical ones. Metadata can still require correction, long-paper excerpt selection can omit relevant information, and valid page numbers do not prove that an answer accurately represents a paper. The local workflow was verified; a cloud deployment or Docker run is not claimed.

5. What I learned and what I would change

A short description of the desired result gave the agent enough direction to begin a substantial task. My preference for concise design and clean colors influenced the interface, and the nearly hour-long first run demonstrated sustained execution across many steps. At the same time, I still needed to make decisions, try the application, and correct outputs that did not meet my expectations.

If I started again, I would prepare the API access and choose the model before asking for the implementation. In this project those decisions came later, after an initial delivery. Stating them at the beginning would make the cost constraint and the requirements for live verification clear from the outset. I would keep the key in local configuration and specify the model explicitly, as I eventually did with `gpt-6-luna`.

I would also make acceptance criteria more concrete: the five working flows, persistent saved data, answers based on the uploaded paper, and readable report figures. My request to render from HTML was more actionable than simply saying the PDF was bad. The experience showed me that an agent can sustain a large amount of work, while I remain responsible for setting its direction and checking whether the result meets the task.

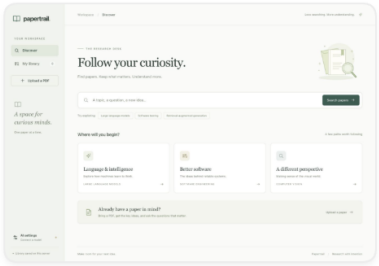
Figure 2. Initial delivery and the unfinished AI setup

This exchange records my response that I would configure the local `.env` file and Codex's initial delivery. The message identifies live AI verification as pending. It provides the context for the concrete configuration and model-selection follow-up in Figure 3.

To verify real summaries and Q&A and record the full demo, add your AP...

I'll configure the local .env file now

Built **Papertrail** with a clean sage-and-white interface. Open the running app.



Implemented all five features from hw1.pdf: search, persistent library, PDF upload, summaries, and Q&A. **14 tests pass**, with desktop and mobile checks completed.

Prepared:

- Setup guide
- Submission checklist
- Demo preview
- Reflection draft: reflection-draft.pdf

Still pending: your API key for live AI verification and the complete demo; your personal reflection and genuine chat screenshots; committing and pushing the code. The local key was still blank at the last check.

- Finish the AI demo
- Personalize my reflection
- Publish the repository changes

reflection-draft.pdf
Document · PDF
Open in

Original student-supplied conversation screenshot, reproduced in full. The setup question is visibly truncated in the original capture.

Figure 3. My model instruction and the verified follow-up

I confirmed that the API key was configured and requested `gpt-6-luna` for lower cost. The reply reports the model change, real summary and Q&A verification, saved-answer reuse, and passing tests. Together with Figure 2, this shows an incomplete integration step, my follow-up input, and the agent's reported result.

Sunday 10:30 AM

I've set the api key and also please use gpt-6-luna for the LLM, it is cheaper

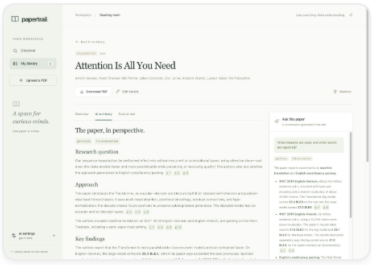
Worked for 10m 3s

Switched to **gpt-6-luna** with reasoning set to `none`. Your key works—real summaries and Q&A are verified, and repeated requests reuse saved answers. All 14 tests pass.

Open the app · Watch the 88-second demo

Updated reflection draft: reflection-draft.pdf

Remaining submission work: personalize the reflection, add genuine chat screenshots, and publish/submit the files.



reflection-draft.pdf
Open preview
Open in

Original student-supplied conversation screenshot, reproduced in full. Statements about remaining work describe the status at the time of the message.

Evidence A: the observed metadata failure

A readable transcription of the original failure: a notice became the title, authors were missing, and the dataset year 2014 was used. The original screenshot remains in the evidence folder.

HISTORICAL EVIDENCE / TEXT TRANSCRIPTION

What the first upload showed

The following values are transcribed from the original failure screenshot. This is a readable evidence record, not a recreation of the application screen.

Title field - visible text

Provided proper attribution is provided, Google hereby grants permission to

Authors

The field was empty.

Publication year

2014

Why the result was incorrect

The title came from a reproduction notice, and the year came from a dataset. The expected paper was *Attention Is All You Need*, with eight authors and a 2017 publication year.

Original evidence is retained in docs/evidence/metadata-before.jpg. Only the clearly visible title, author-field state, and year are transcribed here.

Evidence B: corrected application details

Direct rendering of the application metadata HTML and CSS with the saved paper record. The print layout exposes all eight authors and the complete abstract; text remains selectable when enlarged.

PAPER DETAILS

A quick review.

Make sure the extracted details look right.

Title

Attention Is All You Need

Authors · One name per line

Ashish Vaswani
Noam Shazeer
Niki Parmar
Jakob Uszkoreit
Llion Jones
Aidan N. Gomez
Lukasz Kaiser
Illia Polosukhin

Publication year

2017

Abstract

The dominant sequence transduction models are based on complex recurrent or convolutional neural networks in an encoder-decoder configuration. The best performing models also connect the encoder and decoder through an attention mechanism. We propose a new simple network architecture, the Transformer, based solely on attention mechanisms, dispensing with recurrence and convolutions entirely. Experiments on two machine translation tasks show these models to be superior in quality while being more parallelizable and requiring significantly less time to train. Our model achieves 28.4 BLEU on the WMT 2014 English-to-German translation task, improving over the existing best results, including ensembles by over 2 BLEU. On the WMT 2014 English-to-French translation task, our model establishes a new single-model state-of-the-art BLEU score of 41.8 after training for 3.5 days on eight GPUs, a small fraction of the training costs of the best models from the literature. We show that the Transformer generalizes well to other tasks by applying it successfully to English constituency parsing both with large and limited training data.